

Phobias

People who have phobias tend to feel very anxious about one thing in particular. The thing they feel anxious about may not be dangerous or troublesome to anyone else, but it can make the sufferer feel very nervous and panicky.

GOOD TO KNOW

Obsessive compulsive disorder (OCD)

Some people who are anxious have obsessive compulsive disorder (OCD). To control their anxiety, they feel compelled to do certain things and may have repeated negative thoughts—for example, that something bad might happen or that they themselves might do something bad. The aim of a sufferer's compulsions is usually to try to combat negative thoughts, and can include things like arranging objects, checking things repeatedly, cleaning, or counting.

▷ Common phobias

These are the most common phobias, but there are many more.

Name	Fear of
Acrophobia	Heights
Agoraphobia	Open or public spaces, which makes it difficult for someone to go outside
Arachnophobia	Spiders
Claustrophobia	Confined spaces, which can make it hard to use elevators
Mysophobia/germophobia	Germ
Ophidiophobia	Snakes
Pteromerhanophobia	Flying
Social phobia	Social situations, which can make a person very isolated
Trypanophobia	Needles and injections

Other mental illness

Mental illnesses affect the way people think, feel, or behave. They range from common problems, such as anxiety and depression, to rarer conditions, such as bipolar disorder and schizophrenia. They often start to develop during the teenage years, at a time when many changes are taking place in the brain. Like any illness, consulting a doctor is often the first step toward treating them.



GOOD TO KNOW

Stigma

Sometimes people find it much more difficult to admit to having problems with their mental health than they would if it was their physical health. This can be because there is a stigma about mental illness.

Mental illness, however, is in fact very common, and it's important to talk about it openly with friends and family. Being frank about mental illness enables those who are experiencing it to get the treatment and support they need.

◁ Treatment and medication

There are many treatments available, from counseling to medication.